me. He take 45,000 rupees from me and I see him no more. It seems the judges they play games – I am so totally confused. In Holland they would try me, and within three months if I am guilty they would sentence me to two years, otherwise I would be let off. I would have been out and with my children a long time ago.'

Shakira, an Anglo-Indian kindergarten teacher, had also spent four-and-a-half years here. As she put it: 'My case has not come up for trial as yet. That's the worst with the judicial system, the cases just linger on and even if one is acquitted you find they have already served more than half the sentence for the crime, even while they are innocent. Look at my friend Maria's case. A Spanish tourist, she spent almost six years here. Only last week she was acquitted.'

Michael, an ex-army Englishman charged with smuggling hashish into India, had spent over seven years as an undertrial. His feelings? 'Frustration, yeah and anger. I am a very physical person, and an unbeliever. I don't believe in theory. I don't believe anything, without seeing it myself. This has ruined my life, it's ruined the existence I had. It's ruined the relationship between me and my co-accused who is in the ladies' ward. The judges keep seeming [*sic*] to be dodging. I've been heard by six different judges, but they seem to keep stalling.'

These individuals and so many others were the victims of the country's choked-up judicial system. Overburdening of the judiciary had led to undertrials spending much, much more time than necessary in prison.

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This was the legacy bequeathed to Kiran who was entrusted with the unenviable charge of running Tihar Jail as its new inspector general (prisons) on 1 May 1993.